

This has turned the tide against the power and control of broadcast-era media companies. Now anyone can be a producer of media and reach an audience of hundreds, thousands or even millions, and, in some cases, turn this audience into huge personal wealth.

The production quality of popular YouTubers varies spectacularly. It ranges from very basic and rudimentary content to the high-end editing, effects and structure found in some of the top accounts. Yet, it is the audience who choose and determine what is entertainment, and for many YouTubers, their fanbases are loyal and have an encyclopaedic knowledge of the content. What's more, the producers can interact with the audience in real time.

CASE STUDY 6.13

Emma Chamberlain

Emma Chamberlain began watching YouTube videos when she was six years old, and by the age of 16 she was preparing to quit school to become a full-time content creator. A talented editor, Chamberlain began making video edits for friends that quickly ballooned into a YouTube channel and a full-time career as a content creator, as well as amassing a personal fortune.



FIGURE 6.28 YouTuber Emma Chamberlain, pictured in 2022

Known for her self-deprecating humour and a chaotic editing style that is specific to the internet, Chamberlain has developed her own empire with 12 million followers on YouTube, a podcast, a coffee company and countless paid promotions. Chamberlain has been able to craft an audience through a simple talent for authenticity. Many of her early videos make fun of her own attempts at sewing, cooking or getting her nose pierced, yet her frenetic behaviour is matched by the jump cuts, zooming and distorted editing effects and sound manipulation that reportedly takes the YouTuber between 20 and 30 hours to produce per clip.

Since dropping out of school to create her YouTube channel, Chamberlain has appeared on US talk shows, appeared at Paris Fashion Week and is now a full-time internet celebrity. In the broadcast era, a talent like Chamberlain would have been 'discovered' first, then trained, nurtured and promoted by a media company that would have creative control over her content. However, her content, mostly based around her infectious personality and humour, may never have fit traditional definitions of comedy or performance. It is her own unique style, supported by her own talent for editing to suit a platform like YouTube, that created an audience on her own.

For Chamberlain and thousands of media producers like her, they are their own creative force, attracting the audience who decided to like, follow and share her content.

Analysis

As a class, brainstorm a list of the most popular content producers across a range of media forms.

1. Define the producer and media form they work in.
2. Explain what it is that attracts audiences.
3. Describe the production style. Is it high end? Or rudimentary?
4. How does the media form itself contribute to this popularity?
5. What does this list explain about the capacity for audiences to become producers, and the potential opportunities this can create?

ISBN 978-1-009-36510-9 Hoban et al © Cambridge University Press & Assessment 2023
Photocopying is restricted under law and this material must not be transferred to another party.